

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta **Released September 16, 2025**

Jessica: [\(00:00:00\)](#) Carolynn, we are here today with Christina Cacioppo at the Y Combinator Founder Mode Retreat. Hi, Christina. Hi, Christina. I love doing these in person. It's fun talking face to face.

Now, Christina, we have in the hopper. We have already taped your long form regular Social Radars interview that's gonna be launching pretty soon, which was awesome. Yes. Don't you think, Carolynn? But so today, we're just really gonna focus on talking about Founder Mode stuff and get your thoughts on it.

But first, will you tell our listeners about Vanta?

Christina: [\(00:00:38\)](#) Yeah. We help companies build out and demonstrate trust to their customers. So, practically, that looks like compliance certification, security questionnaires, trust centers, security programs.

Jessica: [\(00:00:50\)](#) I remember being super obsessed with all of this stuff when we're I was like, I never thought I'd be so interested in it, but it's the kind of thing that was very unsexy. Yeah. Right? That companies didn't really wanna spend the time or money or energy, but they had to. So tell us a little bit how you got started on

Christina: [\(00:01:11\)](#) This. Yeah. I've heard someone call these schlep businesses.

Jessica: [\(00:01:13\)](#) Schlep. That's a good business to be in. Yeah.

Christina: [\(00:01:17\)](#) Which actually, do think it's like, Vanta sits at this intersection of your customers or your industry will make you go through various compliance certifications, and so it's necessary to, like, build the business. But it tends not to be what gets a lot of founders or folks out of bed in the morning. Socks too. Right? Okay.

And so you can be at this intersection of people have to do it, but they don't want to. And I think one of the really striking things is people were really appreciative about our early product, which was terrible, but they liked it so much more than they should have because, again, it just did this thing they didn't want to do themselves.

Jessica: [\(00:01:53\)](#) You have to tell the story about segment and the spreadsheets and stuff.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta
Released September 16, 2025

Christina:
[\(00:01:57\)](#) Yeah. So, in the early days, no one had kind of built a product like this. And when you went talked and to people in the industry, they said you couldn't and, you know, they're not to believe them. And so decided to try to build an early version of the product without code, like, in a spreadsheet for a segment on the YC company where we had some friends Mhmm. Who are kind enough to let us sort of hang out in their office and interview their engineers and try to build this prototype.

And I think they were both kind enough, and they needed a SOC two and didn't know how to get it. Anyway and so he spent two weeks in their office reading a bunch of SOC two reports and trying to standardize them and then interviewing their team and kind of making them a road map to here's how you would go do that. And that was, like, the very first version of the product. And then for the second version, we took that spreadsheet literally to another YC company front and sort of gave them segment spreadsheet, but changed just a little bit to see if it worked for them. And that's how we tested if we could standardize what had previously been

Jessica:
[\(00:02:54\)](#) And it did

Christina:
[\(00:02:55\)](#) It. Ad hoc process, and it mostly worked.

Jessica:
[\(00:02:57\)](#) And were you super psyched when that happened?

Christina:
[\(00:02:59\)](#) Kind of. Because it was you kinda didn't know whether it worked. You sort of, like, slide the, like, slide the link across the table. It's awesome. Right?

You know?

Jessica:
[\(00:03:08\)](#) And now you're huge. Kind how big you are. You're huge. Come on.

Christina:
[\(00:03:14\)](#) It's a little, yeah. We are 12,000 customers. We have a thousand people who work at Vanta around the world.

Carolynn:
[\(00:03:19\)](#) Thousand people.

Jessica:
[\(00:03:20\)](#) Yeah. Wow. Okay.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta
Released September 16, 2025

Christina:
[\(00:03:22\)](#) That's so many people. It's wild.

Jessica:
[\(00:03:24\)](#) And between now and when we taped for the Social Radars episode, you've raised a round, or you announced a round.

Christina:
[\(00:03:31\)](#) Yes. We announced a round. We raised our series d. Valuation was 4,150,000,000.

Carolynn:
[\(00:03:37\)](#) Get out.

Jessica:
[\(00:03:38\)](#) Oh, Christina.

Carolynn:
[\(00:03:39\)](#) That's amazing.

Jessica:
[\(00:03:40\)](#) So exciting. I'm so excited for you. Yeah. Me too. So you have gone from sliding that Excel spreadsheet across the table to raising your series d.

Yeah. Tell us things you've learned, how you've grown as a manager, and maybe what your experience with Founder Mode is. What does it mean to you?

Christina:
[\(00:04:00\)](#) For me, I think at the highest level, Founder Mode is almost a, like, permission to run the company the way you want to run it. And I think that's in part because the journey is very long. Even when things work, they're very hard. And so if you kind of don't enjoy it along the way, you just like, it will not work or it will not work for many people, probably myself included. So you kinda have to, like, enjoy the journey or make the journey something you're you, like, jump out of bed for.

And to me, Founder Mode, it's like you should figure that out to yourself and not do what, you know, like, Sand Hill Road VCs tell you to do, which, again, may or may not work. But if it doesn't work for you, it's, like, not gonna work for your company.

Jessica:
[\(00:04:43\)](#) Yeah. Did you ever have something that Sand Hill Road people told you to do?

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta **Released September 16, 2025**

Christina: Oh, absolutely. Like, can you give us an example? Yeah. Let me try to think of a good one. I mean, we had to we, for various reasons, I think we talked on the podcast, waited until we had \$10,000,000 of revenue to raise a series a.
[\(00:04:47\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. I remember the story. Yes.
[\(00:05:02\)](#)

Christina: And that was just weird. And I think, like, not just weird, but folks interpreted it as, like, a lack of ambition. No. Or, like, oh, they don't wanna build a venture backed company, clearly. Oh, wait.
[\(00:05:04\)](#)

Oh, were They were Yeah. Exactly. They're a lifestyle company. And you're like, oh, no. No.

Big one.

Jessica: Like So they were approaching you. And when you said, no. We're not raising it right now.
[\(00:05:21\)](#)

Christina: Too busy. We're set. Thank you. Yes.
[\(00:05:25\)](#)

Jessica: They'd say lifestyle business. Yeah. Interesting.
[\(00:05:27\)](#)

Christina: Yeah. Which I think as you can imagine, I was, like, kinda annoyed. And then I was like, oh, you think that? Great. Well, I look forward to, like, talking to you in a bit.
[\(00:05:31\)](#)

Yes. Like, just you wait.

Carolynn: Have you ever been tempted to delegate to managers not just because, like, you are you know this is a marathon. You've said it. You know? You're in it for the long haul. That's a marathon.
[\(00:05:41\)](#)

You've been around for a long time now. But, like, if you delegate, maybe your life gets a little bit easier. So, like, how do you fight that on a day to day basis?

Christina: That's a good question. I mean, I've definitely delegated stuff that worked and didn't and that I shouldn't have. Okay. So the trope is, like, pick your battles, but I think the version of that is, like I don't know. The Founder always die.
[\(00:06:03\)](#)

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta

Released September 16, 2025

I'm, like, kind of always annoyed when stuff doesn't work. Yeah. But where am I going to be really annoyed, I guess? And, like, where will I be sort of annoyed, but then kind of understand and, like, can kind of move on and trying to know myself well enough and reflect on places there to figure out, you know, kind of what am I mean, like, won't be, like, totally okay with the slipping, but I can live with slipping versus, like, I will just be, like, upset at myself for having delegated that thing. Yeah.

Carolynn: So it's just all about, like, pick like you said, it's picking your battles. Yeah. This is a marathon. I have to delegate some things, but I know myself well enough to know which ones I need to stay in founder mode for. Right.

[\(00:06:45\)](#)

Okay.

Jessica: Yeah. I feel like the concept of trusting your gut has come up. Everyone has their own take on founder mode, but they all sort of say trust your gut. Right. Is there a story that you have where you felt something deeply and followed through on that despite other people?

[\(00:06:56\)](#)

Christina: Yeah. And I can also give you the reverse. Don't know. Yeah. Do both.

[\(00:07:13\)](#)

Yeah. The reverse was actually we lost, like, a very early and excellent engineer who's gone up another, like, has and will continue to have an incredible career. And we lost him because we put a manager over him and, like, kind of knew or in some ways, I, like when I heard that plan, I knew it wouldn't work.

Jessica: Whose plan was it to put a manager over this person?

[\(00:07:36\)](#)

Christina: Their manager. It was gonna put someone in between. In between. And there's, you know, like, you get I there's a there's a you know, Andy Grove would have told you to do this. Right?

[\(00:07:39\)](#)

Like Okay. It wasn't crazy at all. Okay. And I heard it, and I was like, oh, shoot. That's not gonna go well.

I should do something about it. And then it's kind of like, and there's 17 other things, and I'm a headless chicken. And then, you know, kind of the day we told this person, they took an interview and, like, ended up leaving. Wow. Oh.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta
Released September 16, 2025

In a in a very kind and friendly and professional way. Know? But it's actually something you could tell. Like, to this day, I still am like, I am an idiot. And I knew that I was gonna go badly, and I did not do anything about it.

And, like, I do think Vanta is, you know, incrementally worse for that having happened years ago. Totally. Wow. Yeah. Like, you're still a little bit obsessed with it.

Yeah. And, I mean, to be clear, like, I've been great myself, but, like, yeah, totally. I should've got that. Yeah. 100%.

Carolynn: What about the reverse? Obviously, the \$10,000,000, we know that's a great one.
[\(00:08:27\)](#)

Christina: Yeah. You Yeah. And I think both from a business outcome and I think, actually, it helped
[\(00:08:33\)](#) at the time. Again, the company kind of have more confidence in a way because it's like we're doing well because we think we're doing well.

Carolynn: It's not
[\(00:08:44\)](#)

Christina: Like we're doing well because fancy VC says we're doing well. Right. Or, like, that's a nice
[\(00:08:45\)](#) bonus, but, like, not I don't know. That can come and go. Right.

I think the other one or I guess another one is, like, launching additional products before the first one is done. Even in the beginning of the first one, it's never done. But for Vanta, we sometimes talk about it as we didn't start to be a SOC two factory. I'm gonna purposely pedantically calling it a SOC two factory. And we didn't think a SOC two factory would be a good business.

Turns out it's actually a very good business. But still, that's, like, not the plot. And so underlying that is, I think, like, maybe a professional manager would be like, no. It's actually a good business. Like and there's, like, lots of room on market and, just keep going and investing and, like, just do the thing.

But we kind of always thought, like, that's that's not why we're in this. That's not why we've recruited people. Again, like, maybe good business, good financial outcome, but, like, not the game here. And so invested more consciously and larger and earlier on and just trying to get additional products working, because we didn't want to be known for just that one thing.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta
Released September 16, 2025

Jessica: Being a sock factory.
[\(00:09:59\)](#)

Christina: Exactly. Two factory.
[\(00:10:00\)](#)

Carolynn: Yeah. A sock factor is a
[\(00:10:01\)](#)

Christina: Different Yeah. Different business. Factory. Like, I don't have a chance yet.
[\(00:10:02\)](#)

Jessica: I'm thinking about the story you just told about how you felt in your gut, like, you shouldn't put the manager over that person. Yeah. You were too busy. I feel like if I look back on my career at Y Combinator, most of the biggest mistakes that I feel regretful about were, I think, because I was too busy.
[\(00:10:05\)](#)

Christina: Yeah.
[\(00:10:26\)](#)

Jessica: And I thought, ugh. You know, I have other things to fight. And you just get distracted, and you move on, and then all of a sudden, turns into this big problem. Is there any advice you have about balancing sort of being a founder who has a million things to do, listening to your gut, and acting upon it when even when you're too busy?
[\(00:10:26\)](#)

Christina: I mean, if I think of what I was kind of too busy doing, some of it was, like, calendar blocks of my time, but, actually, mostly, it wasn't. It was, like, emotional energy. Right? And I was spending a lot of time in a part of the team that I mean, wasn't working, but, like, wasn't working in a way where it felt like we were, like, all in the boat together. We were, you know, across the shores, like, kind of pointing at each other.
[\(00:10:46\)](#)

And that was just, like, very draining for everyone involved. But I kind of looked back on that, and I think it's like, okay. Well, when you feel like you're in, you know, in the boat pointing at each other, not in the same boat, Fix that real quick because that is so draining, like, emotionally draining, and then you don't have the fortitude for, like, the other stuff. I know that's helpful, but that's kind of it. It's, like, less of a calendar.

I mean, you've calendar problems. Those are easy to solve. It's the, like, no. I just need to lay down for a moment, please. Or, like, I'm done thinking.

Yeah. Yeah.

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Christina Cacioppo, Founder & CEO, Vanta
Released September 16, 2025

Jessica: Has your sense of, like, trusting your gut changed as you've grown to a thousand people?
(00:11:46) Have you as you've done this for more years, raised more money?

Christina: I think so. And I think it's, like, hopefully, it's getting better. But I think I'm more attuned
(00:11:55) to whether you're right or when you're right and you trust your gut, great. When you're wrong and you trust your gut, hopefully, you learn and, like, your gut gets better.

Jessica: Yeah.
(00:12:09)

Christina: If you're right and you didn't trust your gut, I e you did you did the thing you didn't
(00:12:09) wanna do, I don't know. That is just like I get I get really angry at myself. Then. And, like, that is I just kinda wanna avoid that state, I think. And so it's almost like a virgin to that that will lead me to, like, trust my gut more if that is it.

Right. Right? Where you're like, I might be wrong, but at least I will, like, then learn from it. Yeah. Versus I'll just be, like, wrong and bitter.

I'm just, like, not helpful to anyone. You don't

Jessica: Wanna be wrong and bitter.
(00:12:34)

Christina: Bitter is just, like, not good.
(00:12:35)

Jessica: Well, this was awesome. I can't wait for this to air. And if anyone has found this
(00:12:38) interesting, they're gonna be so psyched to hear your full Vanta's journey because it was such a great episode, and it should come out pretty soon too.

Christina: Thank you so much for having me.
(00:12:52)

Carolynn: Thanks, Christina. Bye.
(00:12:53)